

Virjin, Anthony

Mr. Woods

HIST-017B-CHS02

11/20/24

The U.S.A's Reaction

On September 11, 2001, there was a terrorist attack on the Twin Towers in the U.S. This terrorist attack is an awful but significant part of U.S. history as it left a huge impact on a lot of the country. Some of the things it greatly impacted were the country's policies, placement in the global community, and security framework. On this day almost three thousand were killed and the U.S.'s feeling of immunity was instantly destroyed and they were feeling quite vulnerable. The government of the U.S. immediately acted and put in place new security measures, military operations, as well as reformations in foreign policies. These were all implemented for the protection of the people that lived in the United States. Although these did help the security of the nation, they raised many inquiries about civil rights and their preservation, the tricky balance of safety or security and freedom, and relationships around the globe. Throughout this paper, there will be information going over how the United States government immediately responded to the attacks on the Twin Towers like the security measures and the military engagement and operations, as well as the long-term consequences.

Subsequent to the attacks on the Twin Towers during 9/11 the government acted rapidly in order to keep the nation from harm and they passed out new measures of security and military actions. The USA Patriot Act was one of the first major acts that passed after the 9/11 terrorist attacks, passing just six weeks after them. This greatly embiggened the government's capability to surveillance and monitor United States citizens. This made it more accessible for government

agencies to track things like phone calls and emails without requiring a warrant. With the passing of this act, the ability to surveil payments and private property searches was given to the government. This act did help the prevention of future attacks but people worried about it as it was an insane breach of the Fourth Amendment and privacy rights, which is also why it was chastised.¹ The Department of Homeland Security was also created by the government in the year of 2002 and it was made to aid in the prevention of future terrorist attacks by operating with several other agencies to improve border security and synchronize security efforts nationally. Overall these changes were quite dramatic and were a major shift in the way the U.S government controlled security.

In response to the 9/11 attacks, immediately after they happened the U.S. government launched a military operation in Afghanistan because they wanted to break down al-Qaeda, which was the terrorist group that attacked the Twin Towers. The United States really wanted to capture Osama Bin Laden and take down the shelter that protected the terrorists. The justification for the invasion of Afghanistan was that it was necessary to protect the citizens of the United States. It was also justified because it had hoped to destroy the shelters where organizations of terrorists would be able to operate.² This did not just stop here however as in 2003 the invasion of Iraq was launched by George W. Bush. His main claim was that the leader of Iraq had weapons of mass destruction and could possibly be harmful to the U.S. These were not found however and in that region, there was a long-term lack of stability. There were also fatigued relations between several international allies and the U.S. The Iraq war was one of the more

¹ National Commission on Terrorist Attacks, *Final Report of the National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States* (July 22, 2004).

² "Repercussions of 9/11," National September 11 Memorial & Museum, accessed October 24, 2024, <https://www.911memorial.org/learn/resources/911-primer/module-6-repercussions-911>.

disputed outlooks on the War on Terror and helped to grow a division between the U.S. and some of its greatest allies.³

What the government did after the 9/11 attacks was a matter of concern for civil liberties and the freedom of the people. Some stated that it was necessary while others say that it violated personal freedom. One of the more controversial issues was the impact that came with more surveillance on citizens. Primarily on their privacy. While they were under the Patriot Act, the government could access lots of information without any warrant. They were able to access phone calls and emails as stated above. Although they gave reasons for these security measures as being essential for security, there were debates about the possibility of government overreach.⁴ There was also a secret program involving the NSA (National Security Agency) which collected data from the nation's citizens' phone calls and their activity on the Internet. In 2013, a former contractor of the NSA known as Edward Snowden. He exposed the program and revealed the size of what the government was surveilling the United States people. The coming out of this detrimental information caused outrage and called for a reform of laws that monitored the citizens of the United States.

The growing hostility and pressure between protecting security nationally and protecting freedom were also another long-term effect that the post-9/11 measures of security had on the United States citizens. People did support the government in trying to prevent another terrorist attack from happening but there were also many who worried about how moral some certain security measures were. A big example of this was the “enhanced interrogation techniques” which many critics talked about as torture. “Enhanced Interrogation techniques” were used on

³ Sam Hananel et al., *The Lessons Learned for U.S. National Security Policy in the 20 Years since 9/11* (Center for American Progress, May 26, 2022).

⁴ Hannah Hartig, “Two Decades Later, the Enduring Legacy of 9/11,” Pew Research Center, September 2, 2021.

the detainees at Guantanamo Bay and some other military locations. They were used to try and gain intel about possible terrorism threats. The government guarded what was going on here as they disputed that this was also necessary for the protection of the country's security. Many people questioned the use of these methods and this caused moral concern, and also people discussed human rights because of this.⁵

Accusations of discrimination and racial profiling also came to light with the growing power of the government. This was mainly discrimination and racial profiling against Muslim people as well as people who came from Middle Eastern parents. These people faced scrutiny and increased suspicion due to the attacks despite this, none of these people were not involved in any terrorist attacks. This gave concern if people of different religions or ethnicities were under civil rights. These acts by the United States are still disputed to this day, more specifically the bad treatment by the United States to the detainees as well as the influence of surveillance on the citizens of the United States.

The United States's global image and relationships internationally were seriously impacted because of the response that the U.S. had to the 9/11 attacks. In the beginning, the U.S. had lots of support from other countries during its battle against terrorists. However many country's relationships with the U.S were fatigued because of the military operations that the United States was doing. For example, mainly in Europe, some countries such as Germany and France were opposed to the Iraq war. They said that there was not sufficient evidence that Iraq had Weapons of Mass Destruction and that the invasion of Iraq was unjust. This altercation between these nations made trouble as allies in their relations and gave way to criticism of the United

⁵ "Strategic Framework for Countering Terrorism," Department of Homeland Security, accessed October 24, 2024,

States' foreign policies.⁶ An anti-American point of view was rising due to the Iraq War mainly in the Middle East. The U.S. was viewed by many people as pushy and unilateral. There were worldwide protests and people started viewing the United States as an imperial nation.

Democracy was eroding as a result as well as human rights.

The catastrophe that happened on 9/11 made a change in the U.S. foreign policy. Specifically, there was a bigger prominence of the military. People were upset because they believed that this only led to unwanted conflicts that were not needed. The reason they thought this is because the administration of Bush embraced a doctrine that said that the United States would make a move before potential threats and take them down before possibly damaging the nation, giving grounds for the Iraq invasion and what the military did globally.

As time passed, fighting back against terrorism was refined by the United States as with every failure, they learned, and with every victory, they learned. The nation prevented future attacks by focusing on better exchange of intelligence and being closer to partners internationally. The country was being protected from new threats by some agencies as well as the Department of Homeland Security. They made a new program that countered terrorism. They used troops and drones to prey on leaders of terrorists without the need to send the military. This method helped get rid of important characters like the leader of Al-Qaeda there were questions about the deaths of civilians and how moral drone warfare was.⁷

To sum up all that has been stated thus far the reaction to the 9/11 attacks made by the U.S. had some negative long-term effects, at home and abroad. There were many measures taken almost as soon as the attacks occurred, like the security measures. These were necessary to

⁶ Hartig, Hannah. "Two Decades Later, the Enduring Legacy of 9/11." Pew Research Center, September 2, 2021.

⁷ National Commission on Terrorist Attacks "Final Report of the National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States, July 22, 2004.

protect the country from attacks that could possibly happen in the future. Although these methods did work, questions were asked about many things like ethics and civil liberties. What the U.S. learned from the 9/11 attacks to this day continues to have an effect on strategies for counter-terrorism. Even with all this, terrorism is still a threat in the United States and we must find a way to balance security and freedom.

Bibliography

Hartig, Hannah. "Two Decades Later, the Enduring Legacy of 9/11." Pew Research Center, September 2, 2021.

Sam Hananel Senior, Sam Hananel, Senior Director, Doug Molof Director, Doug Molof, Director, Michael Sozan, et al. "The Lessons Learned for U.S. National Security Policy in the 20 Years since 9/11." Center for American Progress, May 26, 2022.

National Commission on Terrorist Attacks "Final Report of the National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States, July 22, 2004.

"Repercussions of 9/11." Module 6: Repercussions of 9/11 | National September 11 Memorial & Museum. Accessed October 24, 2024.
<https://www.911memorial.org/learn/resources/911-primer/module-6-repercussions-911#:~:text=The%209%2F11%20attacks%20prompted,deport%20immigrants%20suspected%20off%20terrorism.>

“The White House Washington.” National Archives and Records Administration. Accessed October 24, 2024. <https://georgewbush-whitehouse.archives.gov/nsc/nssall.html>

“Strategic Framework for Countering Terrorism.” DEPARTMENT OF HOMELAND SECURITY STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK FOR COUNTERING TERRORISM AND TARGETED VIOLENCE. Accessed October 24, 2024.